

Not on my watch!

IN MY SEPTEMBER 2022 COLUMN I WROTE ABOUT TAKING THE PLUNGE AND BUYING A WATCH AFTER 27 YEARS OF NOT WEARING ONE. And of course, I chose to dive in at the deep end and get myself a Samsung Galaxy Watch5 Pro, going from zero experience with a smartwatch to now more than three months of everyday use. I promised to share my experience, so here it is.

For those who read my tragic watch story from 27+ years ago... the good news is that the new one is still in one piece! And that in itself is rather impressive. No matter who you are, you cannot turn off nearly 30-years of learned spatial awareness in a hurry. I walk through narrow openings, walk past pillars or poles, or other people, or just do everyday things such as reaching for things and manoeuvring my hands as if I live in a world sans watches.

The result? I have smashed this watch into all of the aforementioned things, and much more. It's been grazed, face first, on metal, wood, concrete and glass. It's had rendezvous (is that a word?) with pointy edges, has been head-butted by hard substances, and even dropped off my hand when the strap has come undone... That it still looks brand new is a testament to some really good engineering and materials used by Samsung.

Of course when you pay such a lot for a watch, it does hurt when you ram it into a wall. My wife still chortles with laughter at my extremely emasculated cries of horror every time this watch bangs against something. Once I am done examining it for scratches I have to face her exaggerated mocking of my high-pitched squeals!

Smartwatches take a few of the basic features of our phones and put them on our wrists. So which of those features do I use? I can tell you that one of the most important features is using NFC to tap and pay for stuff. It's the absolute norm here in Australia, and sadly, it's a very hit-and-miss experience with the Watch5 Pro. In comparison, my wife's much older Apple Watch 6 just seems to work flawlessly. Since I knew I would be writing this, I did some data collection and counted the number of times she paid for things using her watch over a week or so. I stopped counting at 31 flawless payments. I can't even get the Watch5 Pro to work that way twice in a row! If anything, one in three or

four payments works flawlessly, the other times I have to move my hand about, turn off and turn on the payment mode, or the reader just gives up and denies the transaction! Honestly, I find it less painful to pull out my wallet and take out a card to pay... Thinking it could be a software bug, I have even reset the watch, and upgraded it to the latest firmware, still no dice.

Apart from that, this thing is a rather expensive time-telling device for me. While I appreciate the two reminders it has given me during the writing of this column to stand up and walk around, that's not really a good enough return on my investment. And look I get it, I'm probably the wrong demographic. Younger people, or people who are more into fitness might love this watch, and might even decide to leave their phones at home when they go out jogging. I have no reason to leave my phone behind, so I have no occasion to even want to use my watch.

There are also quite a few bugs that might just be Android or WhatsApp related. For instance, I have a WhatsApp Business account set up on my phone that I have muted all calls for. Can't do that for the watch, and so it rings there. In fact, there are several bugs to be ironed out with WhatsApp especially. I get a missed call on WhatsApp from a colleague, and although the person has hung up, the watch still shows an incoming call, which can stay on the display for hours! Then when I call the person back using my phone, I find that the audio has randomly switched to the watch.

Picture this: I'm walking about in a crowded mall, holding my phone to my ear shouting "Can you hear me Jayesh!", while Jayesh's voice is softly emanating from the wrist on my other hand. What really, really stings is the animated wife, laughing so hard she's crying, doing her "I told you so!" routine, because she is an Apple user, and this is all stuff that's never happened to her.

While I am not planning on switching to Apple yet, I do hate that this brilliant hardware is being let down by mediocre software, and I'm not sure if it's Android or Samsung to blame... 



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